## 1-2 Current data

### Understand the experience using data, research, and available qualitative and quantitative measures

#### Overview

Our customers have been very vocal about their need for a more robust, seamless, and flexible inventory management solution. By analyzing feature requests, cancellation reasons, NPS scores, reviews, and chat logs, a consistent picture emerges: customers want deeper integrations, advanced inventory functionalities, and a more intuitive user experience that minimizes manual work and costly customizations. In this ecosystem, items are not just standalone features; they're an essential part of every transaction.

#### Qualitative Data

**Key Themes:**

Seamless Integration and Connectivity

Customers consistently highlight the need for tighter integration with popular inventory management systems. With direct API integrations requested for platforms like SOS Inventory (17 accounts) and Shopify (15 accounts), it's evident that our users want to leverage external systems without the friction of manual data transfers. This integration need extends to suggestions for platforms like Katana and Inflow Inventory, underscoring that our user base is diverse and seeks a system that works harmoniously with their existing tech stack.

**Cancellation Reasons:**

Customers are frustrated that our basic inventory management features are lacking compared to competitors like SOS Inventory and Cin7, whose out-of-the-box solutions require no additional investment.

- Customers expect comprehensive, out-of-the-box inventory management features.
- The need for further investment in Method contrasts with the immediate functionality provided by competitors, leading to customer switching.
- "Did not have the inventory requirements needed for my Organization"

- “the inventory management portion of the platform (main feature i'm looking for) is not sufficient for what I am doing.”

**Reviews: What do you dislike about Method CRM?**

Customers remark on the lack of automatic integration with their existing inventory software, emphasizing the manual overhead currently required.

- “I would like to see integration with our inventory software so that product lists can be automatically integrated without doing API integration.”
- “Lack of inventory. Not their fault. It's just something we as a company were looking for.”

**Chat Logs: Demand For External Features**

There is an interest in integrating features from other systems (like Fishbowl Inventory) directly into Method. This suggests that Method could benefit from expanding its native inventory functionalities or improving compatibility with popular third-party inventory applications.

- 7 cases were about importing inventory management features from systems like Fishbowl Inventory into Method.
- “Needs to have an inventory software linked to it as well as the CRM. Moving to fishbowl”

**Synthesis:** Together, these points illustrate that customers are not just asking for a "nice-to-have" feature—they require integration as a foundational element to ensure data flows seamlessly between Method CRM and their operational systems.

Advanced Inventory Capabilities

Beyond integrations, our users are asking for more than basic inventory management. They are seeking advanced features—managing multiple warehouses (14 accounts), real-time updates, and detailed location-based tracking (10 accounts) are top priorities, highlight a need for more robust, real-time inventory solutions.

**Cancellation Reasons:**
Customers mention the lack of support for multiple inventory locations and the need for a full end-to-end process that includes advanced inventory tracking.

- “Method does not work with advanced inventory and that is very inconvenient for us.”

- “Need more inventory management features.”
- “We need a full end to end process for Opportunities > Sales Orders > Purchase Orders > Work Orders > Inventory Tracking by Location > Shipping Releases > Invoicing, etc. “
- “You don't support multiple inventory locations.”

**Chat Logs: Sync Issues**

Sync issues, particularly with QuickBooks, point to a reliability gap in current inventory tracking that compounds operational frustrations.

- Customers face challenges when changes are made in one system (e.g., QuickBooks) that do not automatically reflect in Method.
- 10 cases of reported sync conflicts specifically between Method and QB, often triggered by item changes in SOS inventory that didn't automatically update in Method, leading to 1456 unresolved sync conflicts in one instance.

**Synthesis:** The convergence of these data sources underscores a critical gap: our baseline offering does not sufficiently cover advanced inventory management needs. This deficiency is not only prompting cancellations but is also driving customers to seek alternative solutions.

Dynamic and Flexible Item Management

Customers are expressing a strong desire for more dynamic item management features within their CRM system. A significant number of requests focus on item management—26 accounts want the ability to change the sort order on sales orders, 14 want flexible insertion of items in estimates, and 48 demand streamlined conversion of documents into itemized lists for shipping.

**Cancellation Reasons:**

Users are frustrated by the inability to dynamically rearrange or insert items in estimates and invoices—a feature that comes standard in QBO. The need for extensive customization to perform basic functions such as adding or modifying line items without starting over is a significant contributor to customer cancellations.

- “not being able to edit items in the system without paying for assistance from a method employee does not work for me.”

- “Major things that we noticed while creating an invoice is there is no Add Line in between other line items”
- “This is feature is available in QBO, but not Method.  When i asked, it was offered as another customization.”

**Net Promotor Score:** Passive Users

- “Not having the ability to update drop down lists and items is not very user friendly.”
- “I would like to drag and drop to reorder the line items when creating a quote”

**Chat Logs: Inflexible UI Behaviour**

Several interactions mention that items in estimates and invoices cannot be rearranged (e.g., items being added to the top of the list instead of the bottom) or that the order changes upon saving, which disrupts the intended workflow.

- Many of these changes are offered only via billable customization sessions, which frustrates users expecting these to be core, out-of-the-box features.
- At least 20 separate chat interactions mention that users need custom fields, the ability to rearrange or move line items in estimates/invoices, or to modify how items appear (e.g., adding bold formatting or hiding columns).
- “Customer is looking to sort and move items in an Estimate in Method CRM.”
- “The customer may consider switching to a different CRM due to the lack of basic features.”

**Synthesis:** When all data is considered, it’s evident that customers see dynamic item management as essential for operational efficiency. The current system’s limitations in this area are not isolated incidents—they are part of a broader pattern affecting user satisfaction and contributing to churn.

Customization Challenges

A significant issue arises from the current reliance on billable customizations for features that many users expect as standard. This contributes to the overall perception that our system is less adequate compared to competitors who offer out-of-the-box dynamic and advanced inventory features.

**Cancellation Reasons:**

The requirement for extensive, billable customizations to perform what should be standard tasks is a frequent reason for customer departure.

- “Your initial functionality is too basic then you want to charge me 100s of $s for things that should automatically be available as a feature.”
- “Was fixing to buy you guys like $600+ for basic stuff that SOS inventory software does automatically.”
- “Customization, training, and onboarding with Cin7 is a one-time charge of $800.”

**Chat Logs: Customization Demands**

Many customers require significant customization to manage their inventory effectively, such as handling multiple variations of a single item or integrating advanced inventory tracking features.

- 12 cases specifically mentioned the need for customization to manage inventory variations and integrate advanced tracking features directly within Method, indicating a gap in out-of-the-box functionality for complex inventory scenarios.

**Synthesis:** The convergence of feedback here emphasizes that our user interface is not aligned with customer expectations for modern, intuitive design. This creates operational inefficiencies and adds unnecessary cost, further eroding the perceived value of the product.

Item Visualization

Customers are increasingly seeking improvements in how items are visually represented within their CRM system. Specifically, there is a strong demand for the ability to add images to items (32 accounts) on invoices or estimates. This feature helps enhance the user experience by allowing sales representatives and customers to visually verify items, reducing errors and improving the accuracy of selections.

**Reviews: What do you dislike about Method CRM?**

- “We would love a way to organize with photos and show which items have been received in the warehouse.”
- “I wish there was an option to add photos in line items as we are an engineering firm and sometimes item descriptions just don't do a product justice.”

**Chat Logs: Picture Insertion**

Users request additional display options—such as adding pictures to inventory items, indicating that the current UI does not adequately support efficient inventory management.

- “Customer has questions about Method:CRM and wants to add pictures to items in the inventory.”
- “Customer has questions about adding pictures to inventory list”

**Synthesis:** The convergence of feedback emphasizes that customers expect enhanced visual representation of inventory items. Consistent requests for image insertion reveal that the current UI falls short, impacting item verification and overall user satisfaction.

Qualitative Data

**Quantitative Data**

**Items App:**

The quantitative data from 2024 reveals a picture of an app that is actively used, yet faces significant challenges with user engagement and retention.

User Engagement

The following data outlines the engagement metrics for the Items App in 2024.

- Average Daily Active Users (DAU): 312.5
- Average Monthly Active Users (MAU): 2,084
- Users typically open the app ~ 11 times per day
- On any given day, about 15% (DAU/MAU) of our monthly active users are active
  - Are there any friction points in the product that might be discouraging daily use?

Usage by Vertical

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals for weekly usage of the Items App in 2024.

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (850 accounts) ~ 34.6% of the overall average weekly usage
- Field Services (326 accounts) ~ 7.1% of the overall average weekly usage
- Retail (181 accounts) ~ 5.9% of the overall average weekly usage
- Construction (457 accounts) ~ 5.6% of the overall average weekly usage

These percentages clearly illustrate that MWD are the dominant users of the Items App, collectively driving more than one-third of the overall weekly activity.

Item Creation Patterns

The following data outlines what % of items are created on a weekly basis in 2024.

- Inventory Items ~ 73.4%
- Non-Inventory Items ~ 22.9%
- Service Items ~ 3.5%

These percentages clearly illustrate that inventory items overwhelmingly dominate weekly item creation, which highlights a primary focus on physical inventory management, with less emphasis on service-type items.

General Retention Insights

The following data outlines retention insights of the Items App in 2024.

- **Steep Early Drop-off:**
  Retention data indicates a dramatic decline during the first week—from 100% at week 0 to around 56% by Week 1.
  - Nearly 44% of new users vanish after the first week
    - What prevents the other 44% of users from returning?
    - What specific aspects of the onboarding might be causing friction?
    - How can the initial value proposition be communicated more effectively?
- **Gradual Decline Afterwards:**
  Beyond the first week, retention declines more slowly, suggesting that users who overcome the initial hurdle tend to remain engaged longer.
- **Long Term:**
  By Week 52, approximately 31.57% of the original users remain active.
  - Although this is a small fraction, these users are likely the most engaged and valuable.
    - What differentiates these long-term users from those who drop off early?
    - How can insights from this group be used to boost overall retention?

The most noticeable finding is the significant decline in retention within the first week, followed by a more gradual decrease. While only a smaller percentage of users remain active after a full year, these long-term users are critical for sustained success.

Vertical Specific Retention Insights

The following data outlines retention insights for the top 4 verticals by user count in 2024.

- **Wholesale & Distribution:** Post the initial drop, these users maintain a relatively stable retention level (around 40–50% by Week 10 and beyond).
- **Manufacturing:** Starts strong with around 68% retention in Week 1, tapering gradually to the mid-40% range later on.
- **Construction:** Experiences a notably steep decline with retention falling to the mid-to-high teens in later weeks, hinting that the app's value proposition may be less aligned with the needs of this vertical.
- **Field Services:** Shows moderate retention, falling steadily to the 30–40% range.

MWD users exhibit steady engagement after the initial drop, with Field Services showing moderate engagement over time, while Construction experiences a pronounced decline—suggesting the app may not fully meet the needs of that vertical.

**User Journey Insights**

The following data outlines engagement metrics and usage by vertical for each journey in 2024.

User Journey #2: Creating an Opportunity

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Opportunities App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating opportunities daily: 95.97
- Average # of opportunities created on a daily basis: 456.54

Usage by Vertical:

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals creating opportunities on a daily basis in 2024:

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 26.52% of the overall daily opportunities created
- Construction ~ 14.93%
- Field Services ~ 6.73%
- Retail ~ 5.58%

The percentages illustrate that MWD account for more than a quarter of the total opportunities created on a daily basis.

User Journey #3: Creating an Estimate

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Estimate App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating estimates daily: 221.02
- Average # of estimates created on a daily basis: 1930.67

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals creating estimates on a daily basis in 2024:

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 27.13% of the overall daily estimates created
- Automotive parts, repair and maintenance ~9.98%
- Construction ~ 8.31%
- Field Services ~ 7.40%

The percentages clearly illustrate that MWD accounts for more than a quarter of the total estimates created on a daily basis.

User Journey #4: Creating a Sales Order

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Sales Order App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating sales orders daily: 78.2
- Average # of sales orders created on a daily basis: 995.5

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals creating sales orders on a daily basis in 2024:

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 44.78% of the overall daily sales orders created
- Retail ~ 8.51%
- Animal Services, Farming or Forestry ~4.58%
- Automotive parts, repair and maintenance ~2.91%

The percentages clearly illustrate that MWD accounts for nearly half of the total sales orders created on a daily basis.

User Journey #5: Creating an Invoice

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Invoice App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating invoices daily: 256.79
- Average # of invoices created on a daily basis: 2318.77

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals creating invoices on a daily basis in 2024:

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 22.35% of the overall daily invoices created
- Field Services ~ 8.95%
- Automotive parts, repair and maintenance ~ 7.94%
- Retail ~ 5.37%

MWD is by far the leading sector in terms of daily invoice creation, accounting for nearly a quarter of all invoices.

User Journey #6: Creating a Purchase Order

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Purchase Order App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating purchase orders daily: 25.19
- Average # of purchase orders created on a daily basis: 351.52

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals for creating purchase orders on a daily basis in 2024:

- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 24.93% of the overall daily POs created
- Travel and Transportation ~ 15.39%
- Construction ~ 6.52%
- Retail ~ 5.82%

MWD accounts for about one-quarter of al invoices created on a daily basis, followed with travel and transportation as a close second.

User Journey #8: Creating a Proposal

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Proposals App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating proposals daily: 8.05
- Average # of proposals created on a daily basis: 18.84

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals for creating proposals on a daily basis in 2024:

- Field Services ~ 22.45% of the overall daily proposals created
- Advertising, Marketing or PR ~ 10.46%
- Telecommunications ~ 10.05%
- Consulting and Professional Services ~ 8.67%

What % does MWD contribute? 3.95%

Field services top the list leading proposal creation on a daily basis with MWD accounting for a small %, indicating that proposals may not be valuable for MWD workflows.

User Journey #9: Creating a Sales Receipt

The following data outlines engagement metrics for the Sales Receipt App in 2024:

- Average # of accounts viewing, updating, or creating sales receipts daily: 77.04
- Average # of sales receipts created on a daily basis: 215.32

The following data outlines the top 4 verticals for creating sales receipts on a daily basis in 2024:

- Non-profit, govt or religious organization ~ 36.44% of the overall daily proposals created
- Animal Services, Farming or Forestry ~8.58%
- Manufacturing, Wholesale & Distribution (MWD) ~ 7.02%
- Retail ~ 6.46%

Non-profit, govt or religious organizations dominate this list with MWD contributing a small %.

**Synthesis:** The quantitative data highlights that MWD is the dominant vertical across the board, especially in the Items App where it accounts for 34.6% of weekly usage. In every transaction—whether creating opportunities, estimates, sales orders, etc—items play a critical role. MWD drives a significant share of these transactions, ranging from roughly 20% up to nearly 45% in sales orders, underscoring its central role in the ecosystem. This connectivity shows that items are not standalone features; they are integral to every user journey—especially for MWD—highlighting the need to optimize item-related functionalities.

#### Connecting the Dots

Overall, the data converges on a central insight: our customers—especially those in the dominant MWD vertical—are seeking an inventory management solution that is deeply integrated, feature-rich, and inherently flexible. They want to reduce manual interventions—through smoother integrations, automations, and dynamic editing capabilities—and they expect these improvements to be part of the standard offering rather than premium, add-on customizations.